



Not all will be lost

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STAR WARS MUSIC BOX!!

Designer Maximilian Busser is presenting the star wars inspired MusicMachine 3 music box. <http://dgit.in/starwarsmusicbox>

Feature

would call 'great power' and with it comes 'great responsibility'.

Apple Music in a lot of ways is living up to the hype too. Its Beats 1 Radio is a feature that no other streaming service in this list has. Of course, most of them wouldn't have the budget to pull off something like this either. That said, Beats 1 is anything but tailored to India. In addition, even if you listen to a lot of western music, Beats 1 in our experience, seemed fixated on certain genres, especially hip-hop.

What Apple must really be commended for is its library of both Indian and international music. While it has almost every western track that you can search for, its Indian library is not as big as iTunes' is.

Another strength that Apple Music has is its curation engine. It has stations based on moods, activities and what you listen to. And they're all really well done. The real problem though is the app itself. For one, Apple isn't ready with its Android app yet, which means a major portion of the Indian population can't use it on their phones. In addition, iTunes on Windows (which is where you can get Apple Music on Windows) is arguably one of the worst ways to play music that we've ever encountered.

Even the iOS app has its share of issues. While it's a good looking app



Beats 1, not yet out on Android

and runs smooth, the Apple Music app also has too much happening at once. Discovery isn't the easiest here, while it is even more difficult on Windows. Moreover, the social @connect part of the app, though it is another Apple Music-only feature, doesn't really accomplish much. Yes you can follow your favourite artists, but is that really a big incentive for a music app? We don't think so.

Apple Music allows streaming and downloading at 256 kbps though, which means there is no questioning the audio quality that you'll be listening to. You may have a problem with the fact that Apple doesn't allow free streaming. After the initial trial period of three months, you'll have to pay ₹120 per month for the individual plan, or ₹190 per month for the family plan (six accounts).

Rdio

Rdio is one of Apple Music's biggest international competitors. It is also one of the veterans in the streaming industry. Rdio realised last year that it has to tap the huge market that India presents and proceeded to take over Indian streaming service Dhingaana. As a result, Rdio has a commendable collection of Indian music. Commendable mind you, while Rdio has visibly made the effort to add as many Indian songs to its collection as it can, it still doesn't match up to the India-first streaming services that come ahead.

Rdio's strength though is in its western collection. Like Apple Music, the collection of western music that Rdio presents is vast, making it really difficult to find songs that it doesn't have. Some international tracks that Rdio doesn't have, are hard to find in most other streaming services as well.

Rdio also has a social element to it, which the company has always maintained is the differentiating factor for it. It allows you to follow your friends within the app, and uses data from yours and your friends' playlists to improve curation. This gives Rdio a real edge in terms of curation and it is really good at what it does. This element though is a double edged sword, since you wouldn't be able to take full advantage of Rdio's algorithms if your friends don't have the app.

How We Listened

Since we've been using these streaming services for a while now, we were fairly familiar with most of them. So to compare them, we tried out the same music on every streaming service, checking for who has what and how big their own playlists are.

Another aspect of the collection that is really important is the quality of curation. Remember, all these apps call themselves 'Internet radios', which means they want you to listen to the songs that their algorithms find for you. If that is the case, then their algorithm should be good enough to recognise your tastes and suggest the right tracks for you shouldn't it? The same also applies to discovery, because the algorithm is also meant to help you discover new music. We also examined the music quality on each of

the apps, which is another area that they just can't take lightly. Yes, 320 kbps is not what you always need, but a minimum threshold of 192 kbps should be maintained, while 256 kbps should be enough, even for the audiophiles amongst us.

That automatically brings to light another question though. There's no getting over the fact that 3G connectivity in India is still not what it should be. So, is it really possible to stream 192 kbps all the time? The answer is a resounding no, but what we can confirm is that the situation isn't as bad as most people think it is. So, we tried streaming on these apps, on 3G, WiFi and as a pressure test, even on 2G connections. The goal was to find out who can stream longer over these connections and who dropped the ball the fastest.

The availability of the app is of course something that's important. You wouldn't like it if your friend is using an app on his Android phone, while your iPhone doesn't have it would you? More importantly though, the quality of the app was taken into consideration. How easy or difficult is it to manoeuvre your way around it and find music. After all, UI can either make or break a service.

The apps taken into consideration in this comparison were – Apple Music, Rdio, Gaana, Saavn, Wynn, Hungama and Guvera Music. Together, they make for the most popular and best known streaming services today. While some of them will see their way through to the future, some may find themselves down in the dumps. Wouldn't you want to be on the one that doesn't keel over?